

A dark, foggy city street at night. The street is wet and reflects the ambient light. In the distance, a car with its headlights on is visible. To the left, there are buildings with neon signs, including one that says "HOTEL". The overall atmosphere is mysterious and eerie.

HAUNTED

THE QUICKSTART GUIDE

WHAT THIS IS

The case will break you. The past already has. *Haunted* is a tabletop roleplaying game of supernatural noir investigation. You play troubled people working impossible cases in a city that smells like rain and something worse - a place where the dead have opinions, the cults are real, and every case reaches back further than you'd like.

There are no dice. Every uncertain moment is resolved by drawing from a tarot deck, and the whole table reads the card together to decide what just happened. Draw a Major

Arcana and you got what you wanted, clean. Draw anything else and you're negotiating the price.

Every investigator carries a wound at their center — the thing that broke the way they see the world, and the person who put it there. In a full campaign, that wound is the second story running underneath the casework. Tonight, it's the reason your character does something stupid at exactly the wrong moment.

WHAT'S IN HERE

Everything you need to run one session of *Haunted* tonight. Six pre-made investigators, the rules in full, a case to solve, and enough guidance to run it cold. No prep. No character creation. Pick a detective, deal the cards, find the body.

You'll need a standard 78-card tarot deck, two to six friends, index cards, and pencils. Two to three hours. One of you will be the GM.

A NOTE ON CONTENT

Haunted is a game about horror and grief. That's intentional - the darkness is the point. But darkness hits differently depending on who's at the table and what they're carrying.

Before you play, read the Safety Tools section on page 16. It's short, and it's the difference between a good night and a bad one.

HOW A SESSION GOES

Someone is dead, something is wrong, and nobody is talking. Your job is to fix that. You run down leads. You interview suspects. You pay attention to the things people aren't saying along with the things they want you

to hear. When the truth costs something, you draw a card and find out what.

You cannot fail to find a clue. Every lead you follow produces something. The mystery is always solvable. What's in question is what it takes out of you on the way.

BEFORE YOU START

You're going to be tempted to build out a whole life for your character. Don't. Great characters start simple and get revealed session by session. Pick a name, pick a face, and let yourself be surprised.

If you like what happens tonight, the full game funds on Gamefound October 1st. Details on the back page.

TONE

Picture the world of *Haunted* as you would a good supernatural noir.

The neon signs above the shops are perpetually clouded by rain, snow, or fog.

You prowl filthy cities, crowded by suspicious citizens, and alert to ever-present cut-purses and menacing gangsters.

When you visit the countryside, the dangers are those of quiet secrets and contained violence, the horrors we visit on those we love, the hatreds we keep buried for lifetimes. It is cold and hushed and unwelcoming.

Your neighbors are mean and unhelpful, or frightened and vulnerable. The usual suspects are trigger-happy and paranoid, and the cops, your supposed allies in the search for truth, are corrupt, unmotivated, and overly suspicious.

The world of *Haunted* is dark, and should be played that way.

TOUCHSTONES

For further tonal examples, look to *True Detective* (especially Season 1), *Se7en*, *Prisoners*, *LA Confidential*, *Brick*, *The Big Sleep*, *Blade Runner*, *The Sixth Sense*, and *Hellblazer*.

WHAT COMES NEXT

Tonight is one case, run cold, with characters we built for you. The full game is bigger, and darker.

In it, you make your own investigator - you make the skill choices, the personality, you build the ghost that haunts your nightmares. And between sessions, you lick your wounds and try to look that ghost in the eye - Downtime, where you choose between patching yourself up or trying to fix the reason you're broken.

And then the next body turns up, and the mystery gets deeper.

None of it fits in a quickstart. All of it funds on Gamefound, October 1st.

THE READER'S CARD

The next few pages will display the six pregenerated characters suitable for the one shot adventure at the end of this guide - but there is something missing from one of the characters.

In particular, the Reader begins play with a magic spell or item drawn from the deck. For this adventure, we have drawn The Coat of the Chariot.

Here follows the contents of that card so the experience of playing the Reader may be as complete and effective as possible.

THE COAT OF THE CHARIOT

An old coat was buried with the scion of a great family in the city. How did you get your hands on it? What unethical things did you do to make sure it was yours to keep?

This old and tattered coat looks like it was once very expensive and quite fine. Now it looks like something only a hermit would wear.

But when you put it on, you immediately become convinced it is the finest coat you have ever seen. You also become sure that taking the coat off is absurd.

Whenever you reach a hand into the pocket of the coat while in need of money it will immediately produce filthy dollars in the amount you need.

After every time you spend money from your pocket, draw a card.

If you draw a:

Major arcana: You seem a little more sickly but otherwise nothing has changed.

A Court Card: You seem visibly dirtier, even taking off the coat will not fix this immediately.

Anything else: Nothing happens, but check off one of the boxes at the bottom of the card. When all the boxes are checked, turn the card over.

The BULL

Break things. And people.



The Bull is a direct character, but by no means simple. You don't know a lot, but you do know this: whichever Latin jerkoff said, "Fortune favors the bold" was right. Sitting around and plotting all day gives your opponent more time to do what they want to do. They should be worried about what you are going to do to them. Not the other way around. Go pound some fear into these sons of bitches.

Play the Bull if you want to tackle problems head on, or if you just want to add some fun chaos to your investigation.

BULLS IN OTHER MEDIA

Marv in *Sin City*, *Detective Rosa Diaz* in *Brooklyn 99*, *Bart Curlish* in *Dirk Gently's Holistic Detective Agency*, *Gogo Yubari* in *Kill Bill*, *Nick Sax* in *Happy!*, *Bud White* in *LA Confidential*, *Toph* in *Avatar: The Last Airbender*, *Deadpool* in *Deadpool*.

FUN TROPES TO USE WITH YOUR BULL

The Scary One (Rosa Diaz in Brooklyn 99): If smashing a printer with a baseball bat was a personality. You. Take. Things. Too. Far.

The Wild Card (Deadpool in Deadpool): Bugs Bunny mixed with John McClane, you aim for trickster god but land in Menace-to-Society.

BEST PRACTICES FOR PLAYING THE BULL

There is always a small voice at the back of your head telling you to do something crazy. Listen to that voice. Do the crazy thing. Don't let those boring schmucks talk you out of it. You know how to make these stoolies squawk.

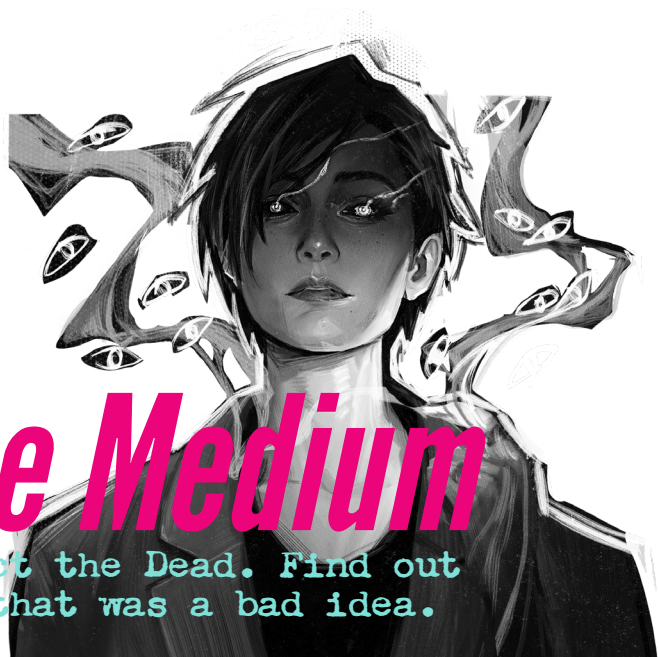
Name:	Domino Michaels	
At a Glance	Sinewy and Mean	
What Ethic will you not bend?	It's not justice if there's no punishment.	
What Flaw can't you shake?	I can't stand authority figures.	
Starting Skills	Busting Heads and Eyeball	Action movie stuff and cop stuff.
Core Ability	Bad Cop	Once per session, when a witness or suspect clams up, you can get them to make one last short, true statement.
Character Ability	Wild-Eyed	Whenever you do something that feels crazy, whatever that thing might be, you do it with <i>advantage</i> .
Downtime Ability	Hit Up Your Snitches	Ask a question of a criminal you know. Tell us the ridiculous thing you do to get the answer.

MY GHOST

My ghost has...	A sweat-soaked shirt and bruises all over their neck	
But I can't shake ...	The way their body suddenly seemed so small	
Who are they to me?	My big brother	
What happened?	I owed money to some people. They found him first.	
How did it make me feel?	Like it should have been me	
And now I think ...	There Is No Justice in the World - Take one trauma: gain advantage on all <i>Bustin' Heads</i> and <i>Get Under Their Skin</i> checks for a scene	
What do I call them?	Benny	

MY PEOPLE

Theresa Jimenez	Shoulder to shoulder, we fought our enemies and won	
Stan Gower	You turned me from a thug to a guardian	
Edgar Rosen	When the time came to run, you stood by me, even though it meant hell for you	
Callum St. Clair	When no one else believed in me, you did	
Celeste Lazuli	I helped you out of a jam, but I used too much force	
Where do you work?	St Clair Investigations	
Why did you join?	Don't like rules.	
What stops you from quitting?	The money spends.	
History Ability	Bodyguard: Pick another character. When you're in scenes with them, you can step in and take damage for them.	



The Medium

Contact the Dead. Find out why that was a bad idea.

The Medium is a conduit to the spirit world. While others walk through the world only catching glimpses of the ghosts everyone knows are there, you are constantly in touch with the Veil. You can choose to pierce the veil and look through to the other side. You can't be sure what is on the other side until you pull aside the veil and look, but you can at least get an idea. That's better than anyone else in the business.

Play the Medium if you want to interact with ghosts. As witnesses they can be ... unreliable ... but sometimes they're the only source you've got.

MEDIUMS IN OTHER MEDIA

Oda Mae Brown in *Ghost*, *Tangina Barrons* in *Poltergeist*, *Lorraine Warren* in *The Conjuring*, *Cole Sear* in *The Sixth Sense*, *Annie Wilson* in *The Gift*.

FUN TROPES TO USE WITH YOUR MEDIUM

Awakened Charlatan (Oda Mae Brown in Ghost): A latent talent has knocked the scales from your eyes, and now the cons you used to run have become uncomfortably real.

Ethereal Conduit (Cole Sear in The Sixth Sense): The ghosts have always been with you. Their pain, their madness — these are the ties that bind your life.

BEST PRACTICES FOR PLAYING THE MEDIUM

Create a ritual before you communicate with a ghost — anything at all, as long as you do it every time. Also, ghosts are scary — lean into that. Are you sure it's a good idea to go down that dark hallway? Of course you're sure; that's where you meet the disturbed ghost who has the clue that will change everything. The scarier the ghost, the sweeter the clue.

Name:	Edgar Rosen
At a Glance	Dramatic and Gaudy
What Ethic will you not bend?	No one is beyond saving
What Flaw can't you shake?	I assume everyone is good
Starting Skills	Give 'Em the Slip and Delude
	Hoodlum stuff and Spy stuff

Core Ability	Pierce the Veil	You can see the Veil. Also, you can tell if a person has been possessed even days after it happened. You can peer through the veil and see ghosts on the other side with a <i>Give 'Em the Slip</i> check.
Character Ability	City of Shadows	You know the ghosts of the city. You can go to them for information. Also, you do not need to check to contact the ghosts you've talked to before.
Downtime Ability	Seance	You hold a seance, calling for any ghost. They will appear and answer questions to the best of their ability.

MY GHOST

My ghost has...	Eyes that don't understand and a short wracking breath
But I can't shake ...	How nothing else changed, even one little bit
Who are they to me?	My best friend in highschool
What happened?	They took too much of a bad batch
How did it make me feel?	Like I should have listened earlier
And now I think ...	I Can't Escape Who I Am - Once per game: gain a skill - every time you use that skill you take a trauma. Anytime you act against your ethic in the first session you gain advantage
What do I call them?	Crazy Tzarina

MY PEOPLE

Domino Michaels	We have clashed over what was the best thing to do
Celeste Lazuli	We held a seance together
Theresa Jimenez	You held me when it became too much
Stan Gower	I helped you solve a cold case
Callum St. Clair	I showed you death is not to be feared
Where do you work?	St Clair Investigations
Why did you join?	Stan bought me a bobble-head doll and promised it'd be fun.
What stops you from quitting?	I actually do a fair amount of good for the ghosts we see.
History Ability	Choose a character to be your anchor. Your anchor can see what you see when you pierce the veil. They can also pull you out after a bad check in order to avoid the repercussions of the check.



The Reader is powered by an insatiable need for knowledge. If you could only find the right book, in the right private library, then you would finally know how it all works. And once you know that, then you can change the world. If you could only find it!

Play the Reader if you want to learn magical spells. If you want to be tempted by magical artifacts that no one should have made. But beware, knowledge is a heady concoction and in finding power, you may lose yourself.

READERS IN OTHER MEDIA

John Constantine in *Hellblazer*, *Dean Corso* in *The Ninth Gate*, *Harry Dresden* in *The Dresden Files*, *Peter Grant* in *Rivers of London*, *Willow Rosenberg* in *Buffy the Vampire Slayer*, *The Scarlet Witch* in *Doctor Strange in the Multiverse of Madness*.

FUN TROPES TO USE WITH YOUR READER

The Closeted Megalomaniac (*The Scarlet Witch in Doctor Strange in the Multiverse of Madness*): You've lost respect for humanity and don't know how you'll ever get it back.

The Magic Detective (*Harry Dresden in The Dresden Files*): The world is dangerous in a way only you understand. You stand between eldritch horrors and ordinary people, and they'll never know.

BEST PRACTICES FOR PLAYING THE READER

The Reader doesn't know when to stop. They'd put a third mortgage on their parents' home without thinking about it if they could just get five minutes alone with "Viginti duo eorum arcana et ritus". The Reader has the most tempting Downtime Ability in the game. With *Acquire Tomes*, the deck is filled with eldritch spells and ancient items, bursting with arcane powers. If you are the sort of player who isn't especially motivated by the *Redemption Arc*, then with the Reader, you can burn bright and gain power.

Name:	Celeste Lazuli
At a Glance	Vintage and Well-groomed
What Ethic will you not bend?	Secrets must be revealed
What Flaw can't you shake?	I obsessively collect books
Starting Skills	Hit the Books and Eyeball
	Nerd stuff and Cop stuff

Core Ability: Esoteric Knowledge
Once per session you can declare that you read about this somewhere and use Hit the Books instead of whatever skill you were about to use.

ALSO: Start the game with *The Coat of the Chariot*

Character Ability	Rare Editions	Once per session, you may find a valuable piece of knowledge about something arcane or occult.
Downtime Ability	Acquire Tomes	You seek out arcane knowledge. What library do you search in? What does the restricted section look like? Draw a card. Consult the GM to find out what it means.

MY GHOST

My ghost has...	A silly, hopeful look on their face and wet hair tangled with leaves
But I can't shake ...	How I couldn't get them to let go
Who are they to me?	A fellow student
What happened?	He fell, still clutching the book he was trying to steal from me
How did it make me feel?	What a waste
And now I think ...	Everyone Is Guilty - Take one trauma to ask if a statement was a lie
What do I call them?	He was only ever McCleod - I never knew his given name.

MY PEOPLE

Edgar Rosen	I bought a rare book from you. How did you have it?
Stan Gower	I did some research for you and saved your day. What piece of knowledge did you need?
Theresa Jimenez	You and I met on a site for a conspiracy theory. What was it?
Domino Michaels	You saved me when I got in over my head. What was I researching that go me in trouble?
Callum St. Clair	We were students together. When and where did we meet?
Where do you work?	St Clair Investigations
Why did you join?	Callum turned a whole office into a library.
What stops you from quitting?	I know the spot on my desk that stops a pencil from rolling off.
History Ability	Protective Talisman: You have given another player a talisman that will protect them. It can cancel one side effect per session.



The Shamus is the classic noir detective. Good at finding clues, bad at knowing when to give up. You don't talk to ghosts, you don't read books in Akkadian, you just solve cases, and put the bad guys where they belong.

If you like building murder boards and following leads, then the Shamus is the character for you. But be warned, the Shamus is better at getting into jams than they are at getting out of them.

SHAMUS IN OTHER MEDIA

Brendan in *Brick*, *Philip Marlowe* in *The Big Sleep*, *Rust Cohle* in *True Detective*, *Fake Gittes* in *Chinatown*, and *Veronica Mars* in *Veronica Mars*.

FUN TROPES TO USE WITH YOUR SHAMUS

The Decent Bastard (Rust Cohle in True Detective): "The world needs bad men; we keep the other bad men from the door."

The Hard-Boiled (Brendan in Brick): "I don't like people telling me whose side I'm on."

BEST PRACTICES FOR PLAYING THE SHAMUS

The Shamus pushes things. They take unreasonable positions. Are justice and kindness on opposing sides? The Shamus chooses justice. Sam Spade sends the woman he loves to jail for the murder of a man he didn't even like. Sometimes the outcome that no one wants is the only one that justice demands. For the Shamus, justice always wins.

Name:	Stan Gower	
At a Glance	Relentless and Weary	
What Ethic will you not bend?	Everyone deserves justice	
What Flaw can't you shake?	I am rude to violent people	
Starting Skills	Eyeball and Busting Heads	Cop stuff and Action Movie stuff
Core Ability	Smell a lie	Once per session you can ask the GM if the witness is lying. They will say "yes" or "no".
Character Ability	I Don't Know How to Quit	When you draw a <i>staves</i> card, you can describe a harrowing event you lived through in the past and uncheck your last injury box.
Downtime Ability	Old Cases	You go through old case files and news stories. You find something from the past that affects the current case.

MY GHOST

My ghost has...	Hands covered in blood and holding rusty scissors
But I can't shake ...	How easy it was for you to cover it all up
Who are they to me?	The son of my last client
What happened?	Guy was caught in a cycle of abuse/abuser - when he realized I knew, he couldn't even wait for the bath.
How did it make me feel?	Like a fool
And now I think ...	I'm All Washed Up - You can fail a check automatically to heal one trauma. You cannot gain trauma as a downside of this failure.
What do I call them?	Elijah

MY PEOPLE

Domino Michaels	You were my first partner.
Theresa Jimenez	You stood by me when I was crazy. I stood by you when you were drunk. Now we stand by each other.
Callum St. Clair	We brought justice to the city together
Edgar Rosen	When I formed the detective agency, you were my first call.
Celeste Lazuli	When the time came, you made the hard decision. I respect you for that.
Where do you work?	St Clair Investigations
Why did you join?	Thought it'd get me a quiet life.
What stops you from quitting?	All my friends are here - where else would I go?
History Ability	Tag Team: Choose another player as your partner. When you question witnesses together, you can each get 1 check of your choice at advantage.

The Shrink

Look inside monstrous minds.

The Shrink specializes in catching the killer because you understand them. Sometimes you understand your suspect better than they do themselves.

Play the Shrink if you want to get criminals to tell you things they wouldn't trust to their own mother, or if you see a mystery as a cat and mouse game between murderer and sleuth.

SHRINKS IN OTHER MEDIA

Clarice Starling in *The Silence of the Lambs*, *Holden Ford* in *Mindhunter*, *Lt. Frank Columbo* in *Columbo*, *Will Graham* in *Red Dragon*, *Alex Cross* in *The Alex Cross Series* by James Patterson.

FUN TROPES TO USE WITH YOUR SHRINK

The One You Underestimate (Columbo in Columbo): You bumble along, haphazard and goofy, but when the time is right, you trap overconfident villains into making mistakes.

The Empath (Will Graham in Hannibal): When you look into the abyss, the abyss looks back at you. You find yourself empathizing a little too closely with the psychopaths you hunt.

BEST PRACTICES FOR PLAYING THE SHRINK

No matter what kind of Shrink they are, they are the sort of person who analyzes others, and looks for weakness to exploit.

Name:	Theresa Jimenez
At a Glance	Gentle and Bright
What Ethic will you not bend?	Hurt people hurt people
What Flaw can't you shake?	Everyone has a pathology
Starting Skills	Get Under Their Skin and Delude
	Provocateur stuff and Spy stuff

Core Ability	Good Listener	Once per session tell us what you do to make an NPC feel like they are in a safe space. Then ask them one question. They will answer fully and truthfully.
Character Ability	A Dangerous Method	Once per session you may declare an NPC to be one of your former patients. Tell us what embarrassing secret they have. You have <i>advantage</i> on all <i>Get Under Their Skin</i> checks involving them.
Downtime Ability	Create a Profile	You spend the night pulling together case work from other crimes. This type of crime has a specific kind of unsub. The GM will give you a mental description of the killer.

MY GHOST

My ghost has...	A broken doll in their hands and a manic, unflinching smile on their face
But I can't shake ...	How they were so sure they deserved what happened
Who are they to me?	My grandmother
What happened?	We talked, and she remembered something that happened a long time ago, and that thing prompted her to stab my uncle in the neck. She died in the asylum a year ago.
How did it make me feel?	Powerful. Too powerful.
And now I think ...	I Don't Matter. - Take one trauma to gain advantage on all <i>Give 'Em the Slip</i> and <i>Delude</i> checks for a scene.
What do I call them?	Nana

MY PEOPLE

Edgar Rosen	You were an old patient of mine.
Callum St. Clair	After my habits destroyed my practice, you gave me a job.
Stan Gower	When all seemed lost, I consulted on a case and got you a fresh lead.
Domino Michaels	You were always too impulsive. I secretly wish I could be that way.
Celeste Lazuli	You cultivate friends. Sometimes I feel like I'm just another piece of your garden.
Where do you work?	St Clair Investigations
Why did you join?	Any port in a storm, you know?
What stops you from quitting?	My reputation is in tatters - what else would I do?
History Ability	Halo Effect: Choose a character. After either of you gets a success, the other gets advantage on their next check.



The UpperCrust

We go way back. I know where all the bodies are buried.

The UpperCrust is all about access. You golf with the mayor's nephew. You brunch with the police commissioner's secret girlfriend. Your bridge partner is consigliere to one of the city's most prominent crime families. You know all the best people. And some of the worst. You solve cases because you know how the system works and how to work the system.

Play the UpperCrust if you want to pull the strings and influence people.

UPPERCRUSTS IN OTHER MEDIA

Nick and Nora Charles in *The Thin Man*, *Cedric Daniels* in *The Wire*, *Jeffrey Beaumont* in *Blue Velvet*, *George Smiley* in *Call for the Dead*, *Edmund Exley* in *LA Confidential*.

FUN TROPES TO USE WITH YOUR UPPERCRUST

The Frivolous Dilettante (Nick Charles in The Thin Man): The whole world is a game, and you like to play it. A bit of gun play might just make your day!

The Ambitious Mover and Shaker (Edmund Exley in LA Confidential): You are on your way up, and nothing is going to stop you. You will do what has to be done to make your way in the world.

BEST PRACTICES FOR PLAYING THE UPPERCRUST

You know everyone. And everyone knows you. As soon as you meet any NPC, bring up something scandalous that you know about them. "Oh Gilda, the last time I saw you, you had your ankles over your ears at Charlie's big summer frolic."

Name:	Callum St. Clair
At a Glance	Witty and Absurd
What Ethic will you not bend?	The system works.
What Flaw can't you shake?	I flirt with everyone I talk to.
Starting Skills	Delude and Hit the Books
	Spy stuff and Nerd stuff

Core Ability	Friends in High Places	Once per session you may call on a powerful friend. Name them and your relationship. They can get you something that is practically impossible to get.
Character Ability	I Want to Talk to Your Manager	Twice per session you may make a <i>Delude</i> check with <i>advantage</i> if you can say "I want to talk to your supervisor" with a straight face.
Downtime Ability	Fancy Party	You attend a fancy party (have the other players play people at the party) and learn something that is kept a secret outside of the highest echelons.

MY GHOST

My ghost has...	A huge hole where one eye should be and an oddly calm look on their face
But I can't shake ...	The way they stared at me the whole time.
Who are they to me?	An old school rival - a scholarship student
What happened?	He lost his eye (and his scholarship) in a non-official fencing duel, and no one from his family came to pick him up.
How did it make me feel?	Like life could be so much worse.
And now I think ...	I've Got This All Under Control. - Take 1 trauma to take another downtime action (Neither of the two downtimes can be family time)
What do I call them?	Poor Jacobs

MY PEOPLE

Theresa Jimenez	You were my friend when I was poor.
Celeste Lazuli	We went to school together.
Edgar Rosen	We tackled a rough problem together.
Stan Gower	You were the first person I hired.
Domino Michaels	Together we forged a better world.
Where do you work?	St Clair Investigations
Why did you join?	I own it - I love puzzles, and adventure, and thrills.
What stops you from quitting?	I owe it to my staff to keep going.
History Ability	Mentoring: Choose another character to mentor. Once per session you may make their next draw into "Draw 3 cards and choose one."



GENERAL MECHANICS

Every game we've ever played, since the dawn of time, has rules.

Chase, Tag, Tickle Monster, Risk — they all have things you can and cannot do —

"No tag backs!"

"No, you cannot convoy your troops and land in Australia."

In *Haunted*, our rules cover three things: the safety tools we use, the cycle of play, and how we resolve uncertain situations.

SAFETY TOOLS

Haunted is a game about horror and grief.

That's intentional — the darkness is the point.

But darkness hits differently depending on who's at the table and what they're carrying, and the best session is one where everyone can lean into the story without dreading where it might go.

These tools make that possible.

LINES AND VEILS

Before you play, your GM will ask the table two questions. First: are there any topics that are completely off the table? These are your Lines — things the story won't go near, full stop. Violence against children is a common one, but every table is different and there are no wrong answers.

Second: are there things you're okay

including, but want to handle at a distance, without detail? These are your Veils — the camera cuts away, the scene fades to black.

The thing happened, but we won't dwell on it.

Lines and Veils aren't set once and forgotten. Check in periodically. A topic that felt fine in session one might land differently in session five.

THE X CARD

Sometimes something slips through anyway. A scene goes somewhere nobody anticipated, and someone at the table needs it to stop.

For this we have the X Card. Something physical on the table that anyone can grab or tap, quickly, at any moment, no explanation or justification required. When it comes out, the scene stops and the subject changes. No questions, no debate. You can talk it over afterward if the group wants to, and update your Lines and Veils accordingly.

The X Card only works if everyone at the table agrees in advance to respect it without hesitation. That's the whole contract.

SKILLS

Skills are how you interact with the game's resolution mechanic. When you make a check, you're drawing on one of the six skills below — and if two feel like they could apply, talk it out with your GM.

Busting Heads	Fighting, chasing, powering through. Action movie stuff.
Delude	Lying, fast talking, persuasion, disguise, bureaucracy. Spy stuff.
Eyeball	Noticing small details, being alert, searching. Cop stuff.
Get Under Their Skin	Seduction, intimidation, unsettling someone. Provocateur stuff.
Give 'Em the Slip	Escaping, sneaking, dodging, pickpocketing. Hoodlum stuff.
Hit the Books	Research, library use, the internet, cyberstalking. Nerd stuff.

RESOLUTION

All roleplaying games have a resolution mechanic. In *Cops and Robbers* or *Playing House*, fraught situations are resolved through consensus and argument. In *Dungeons and Dragons*, a D20 is rolled. In *Haunted*, we draw from a Tarot deck.

We only draw from the Tarot deck if you're employing a skill in a situation where it could matter, with real stakes. It's one thing to hit a target at the shooting range while you're calm. It's another thing to do so when the target is shooting back at you.

WHAT'S IN A TAROT DECK?

Seventy-eight cards. Twenty-two of them are the *Major Arcana* — the famous ones, names and no suit: The Tower, Death, The Hanged Man.

The other fifty-six are the Minor Arcana, dealt across four suits — Staves, Cups, Swords, and Pentacles (your deck might call them something else). Each runs two through ten, the *numbered cards*, plus five *court cards*: Page, Knight, Queen, King, and Ace.

You don't need to know what a single card "means." *Haunted* tells you how to read them. But if the picture gives you something — a drowned figure, a falling tower — take it. The best draws are the ones the table reads together.

HOW CHECKS WORK

When you make a check in *Haunted*, you draw from the Tarot deck. What you draw tells you how well things went — not just yes or no, but how yes or no.

Draw a Major Arcana? Full success. You got what you wanted, clean.

Draw a court card? That's a complicated success — but only if you have a relevant skill. Without one, treat it as a numbered card.

Draw a numbered card? That's a pyrrhic success, or possibly a failure. You might still get what you wanted, but it's going to cost you.

COMPLICATED SUCCESSES AND PYRRHIC SUCCESSES

If you've played *Powered by the Apocalypse* games, this will feel familiar.

A complicated success means you got what you were going for — but one bad thing also happens. The GM decides what that bad thing is. It's a success, but it comes with strings.

A pyrrhic success turns up the dial. You still succeed, but now you're looking at two bad things, or one significantly bad thing. If the situation is bad enough, you can ask the GM to just let you fail instead — take one bad thing and call it done. Sometimes a contained failure is better than a catastrophic win.

You can still draw a complicated or pyrrhic success — things can go sideways, and probably will — but there is no check in *Haunted* that stands between you and solving the mystery. Some of the best detectives in fiction would have it no other way. They may not be able to walk by the end of it, but the case gets closed.

You CANNOT fail when checking to gain evidence.

ADVANTAGE AND DISADVANTAGE

When the GM determines that the situation is working against you — a gunfight while

hanging off the side of a building, say — they can call a check at **Disadvantage**. Draw two cards, use the worse result. When things are in your favor — chasing a suspect with a broken leg — they can call it at **Advantage**. Draw two cards, use the better result.

INTERPRETING DRAWS

The next concept is one of the best parts of the game.

After every check, there's a moment where the table figures out exactly what happened — and **the card you just drew is an invitation**.

If you catch a suspect in a foot chase by drawing **Judgement** (Major Arcana XX), maybe police cars suddenly converge on the alley, lights flashing, sirens blaring, and the suspect realizes it's all over.

But if you drew the **Three of Cups** in a pyrrhic success, maybe you catch up to them only to see their two buddies step out of the shadows, coshes and brass knuckles at the ready.

You don't have to use the cards this way, but **the best interpretation usually comes from the whole table throwing out ideas and seeing what clicks**.

The GM has the final call, but in *Haunted*, you're all writing this story together, and the best idea wins.

RESHUFFLING THE DECK

Reshuffle whenever the GM wants to, and whenever the deck runs dry. Or whenever your fingers feel itchy. It genuinely doesn't matter.

SOLVING CASES

Every case in *Haunted* starts the same way: Someone is dead, something is wrong, and nobody is talking. Your job is to fix that.

Whatever the mystery novels might suggest, investigation is less about flashes of brilliant deduction and more about legwork.

You run down leads.

You interview suspects.

You pay attention to the things they aren't saying along with the things they want you to hear. People are bad at lying, especially under pressure, and a skilled investigator knows exactly how to apply that pressure. Run down enough leads, and the truth starts to come out.

You cannot fail to find a clue. Every lead you follow will produce something — it may cost you, but you will always come away with more than you had. The mystery is ALWAYS solvable. Trust the process.

THE PLAYBOARD

You're going to get a lot of leads. A lot of clues. To keep track of everything, *Haunted* uses a simple tool called the Playboard, which is a fancy name for a pile of index cards in the middle of the table.

Here's how it works: whenever a lead surfaces — a name dropped by a witness, a relationship that doesn't smell quite right, an organization that keeps being mentioned — the GM **writes it on a card** (or a player, really — if you can hold a pencil, you can create a lead card) and **puts it on the table**.

As you learn more about a lead, you **update that card**. At any point you can look at the spread in front of you and see exactly what you know, what you've followed up on, and what still needs to be checked out.

Some cards will be there from the start — victim's name, immediate family, the first facts of the case. You'll create the others as you dig.

The Playboard isn't so much a puzzle as it is a red-yarned murderboard you're building in real time (you can try the red yarn thing, if you want — we didn't find that it made much of a difference — but go off, king). Whenever you get stuck, look at the cards. Something on the table almost always points to what to do next. In the extremely rare case that it doesn't, communicate with your GM — there's probably been a missed connection

somewhere and the GM can throw you a lifeline.

TAKING INJURIES AND TRAUMA

When a check goes badly, the GM may tell you to mark an injury or trauma on your character playbook. Each track has three boxes, and they fill in order — you can't just pick and choose which of the injuries or traumas you want to take.

Injury Boxes:

1. One check per session is at **Disadvantage**
2. **Disadvantage** on all checks
3. Debilitated — You fail all checks

The GM decides which check your injury affects — if your leg is broken and you try to chase someone down an alley, expect to hear about it. These effects persist until you've taken a healing Downtime Activity (available in the full version of the game).

Trauma Boxes:

1. Describe your character trying to keep their cool
2. One check per session is at Disadvantage
3. Traumatized — you cannot use your abilities

Box 1 is a roleplay prompt — lean into it. Boxes 2 and 3 are mechanical and persist until you heal it in Downtime (full game). Until then, the GM decides which check your trauma applies to.

HEALING AND DEATH

There is no natural healing in *Haunted*. You have to take a **Downtime Activity** to heal your trauma or your wounds. However, without player buy-in, there's also no death in *Haunted*.

Investigators crawl over broken glass to solve their cases — don't be precious about saving your skin.



GM TIPS FOR USING THE RESOLUTION MECHANICS

WHEN TO USE THE RULES, AND WHEN NOT TO

The first and most important rule of *Haunted* is *never make the characters do a check that you are not okay with them failing*.

You can declare any action a success just by agreeing that the character does it, no need to tempt fate and draw from the deck. But if the story might benefit from them failing or incurring consequences, by all means, bring out the deck!

THE OUTCOMES OF CHECKS

A check can go in a few different ways, and all of them require that you, the GM, have to imagine outcomes that are –

1. tonally aligned with the story
2. interesting enough to be worth talking about.

This is not a small ask. This is where your strength as a storyteller comes to the fore. That said, I can give you some guidelines to lean on.

FULL SUCCESS

When a character draws a full success (a major arcana), you should look at the card and let it inspire you. Use it to help you describe the outcome.

The character's success is the least interesting part of this process – sure, they do the thing, but what else happens?

So long as there's no explicit harm to the character, let the card lead you towards knock on effects. For instance, if they're trying to win a fight, and they draw the Death card, maybe they win that fight by accidentally killing their opponent.

If the Hanged Man shows up during an interrogation, maybe they catch the target as she lunges out a window, and now the information comes while the target dangles over a city street.

If they pull the Hermit, maybe their success comes out of deep knowledge they didn't know they had – ask them what part of their history would generate such deep knowledge.

Full successes always contain the intended result – the thing that makes them amazing is the additional depth inspired by the contents of the specific card, and the imagination of the table.

For every draw other than a major Arcana, the check will have consequences that affect the character. But “consequence” is a very broad category. What do we mean when we say “Consequence” in *Haunted*?

CONSEQUENCES

When a character makes a check and it isn't a *full success*, it has *consequences*.

Consequences are in-game effects that make the situation more tense and interesting. In *Haunted*, we figure out what these are by looking at the card that was drawn for the check. We check two things...

THE ART ON THE CARD

The first rule is to look at the card. As with a full success, the art on the card can give you inspiration for what kind of consequences the character's actions might generate.

For example, the player draws the V of Staves. I look at the art and I see a fight. It makes me think, “A big brawl could break out and give cover for our villain to escape. Maybe the player gets punched in the face by a rando.”



That said, if you look at the card and nothing jumps to mind, it's not a problem. In that case, we check...

THE SUIT OF THE CARD

Use the following table to tell you what consequences go with which suit.

Swords	Injury if appropriate, otherwise up the stakes.
Cups	Trauma if appropriate, otherwise complicate the situation.
Pentacles	If appropriate, ghost and spooky stuff happens. The ghosts should be disturbing and scary.
Staves	Ask them how this moment reminds them of their past trauma. Otherwise, be mysterious and try to frighten your players.

WHAT IS “UPPING THE STAKES”?

The question of how high or low the stakes are is inherently context-dependent, but essentially, if you make the situation more dangerous, and make the reward for succeeding bigger, you will have upped the stakes.

For example:

- Spiderman battling Kingpin over interdimensional technology that could obliterate an entire timeline is objectively HUGE STAKES.



- A dance contest for bragging rights is objectively very low stakes.

One of your jobs as GM is to constantly be looking for opportunities to up the stakes, but the task isn't black and white.

Both of the above situations would be recognized as high or low stakes situations in almost all stories, but they change with perspective.

If the audience cares about Carl, a grumpy old man who just wants to honor his wife's memory, even the backdrop of interdimensional chaos and destruction won't distract from the drama of Carl tearing apart his living room, looking for Ellie's wedding ring.

Stakes are high or low according to what the characters actually care about.

WHAT IS "COMPLICATING THE SITUATION"?

Where Upping the Stakes was complicated, Complicating the Situation is simple. You complicate the situation just by introducing elements that make success harder to achieve.

These are elements like:

- The police show up
- The room is on fire
- Literally anything changes for the worse.

The characters are juggling violence, mystery, and trauma. All you need to do to complicate the situation is add one more problem to the mix.

WHAT IS THEIR PAST TRAUMA?

The memory of the person they failed.

Their failures, begging them to give up.

Have them describe the moment that comes back to them. Let them linger on what they did wrong. Ask them,

"How does this moment remind you of your past trauma?"

COMPLICATED SUCCESSES

A Complicated Success means the character got what they wanted, but there was a consequence.

PYRRHIC SUCCESSES

A Pyrrhic Success means the character got what they wanted, but there were two consequences. This doesn't mean that the characters suddenly take so much damage that they have to stop playing to go heal or something — consequences aren't limited to injury or trauma.

Never, and I mean **NEVER**, keep the investigators from getting a clue just because they did badly on a check!

FAILURE

Some players see the pyrrhic success and get anxious. This is normal, maybe even intended.

If a player doesn't need a success and would rather just take a consequence and roll on with their lives, they can choose to fail a check.

I would advise you to use this very sparingly. Complications are much more fun than failures.



RUNNING THE MYSTERY

A GUIDE TO FLYING BY THE SEAT OF YOUR PANTS.

"We have to continually be jumping off cliffs and developing our wings on the way down."

-Kurt Vonnegut Jr.

This is going to feel counter-intuitive. Every one of us is an astute student of stories. We wouldn't be playing these games if we weren't. But writing and reading are different experiences, with different mechanisms.

Reading a murder mystery feels like witnessing an incredibly intricate unfolding of interlocking gears, something a mere mortal could never hope to reproduce. Writing a murder mystery feels like ... something else.

THE MAKING OF ART IS DIFFERENT FROM THE EXPERIENCE OF IT.

As the GM, your job is to lurk behind the curtain and manage all the gears and machines that create the experience.

Because you're used to receiving the experience, you can expect to be somewhat disappointed by how non-miraculous the management process is.

It might even feel like a cheap trick, almost like the first time you found out that your grandfather wasn't magic, *the coin was just in his other hand*.

Welcome to the other side of the magic equation.

It doesn't feel like magic over here, but creating a thrilling experience for your players more than makes up for it.

Time to deploy some cheap tricks.

THE FIRST CHEAP TRICK: THERE IS NO KEY IN NADIA'S POCKET

"Try to realize the truth... There is no spoon. Then you'll see that it is not the spoon that bends, it is only yourself."

-That bald kid in The Matrix

Let's say that in your mystery, Nadia Goodkin's body has been found in the woods behind the Society of Shadows' estate. Your players start to look for clues.

Your goal is to give them a lead that will take them to the next scene, a room in the Guardian Motel, and get them one step closer to solving the mystery.

Your job is to give them a clue as soon as they do something to deserve it.

The most important of these clues is called a **lead**. It is a clue that takes the characters to a new scene.

No matter what, make sure they get this clue!

A clue is in the first cool place they look. Emphasis on "cool" – the first time you think, "That's a great place to find a clue!" that's where you put it.

- Do they look in her purse? She kept a receipt for booking the room.
- Do they look under her body? There is a matchbook on the ground for the motel.

You do not care what the specifics of this clue are. You only care that it gives them a prompt to move on to another scene.



Whatever you do, do not hide a clue.

The players have no access to the mystery outside of you. No way to search a room, no way to interrogate a suspect.

If you deliberately prevent them from receiving a clue because "they didn't ask the right question," you have made yourself an obstacle to not just solving the mystery, but playing the game in its entirety.

Don't be that guy.

THE TRUTH IS THERE IS NO KEY IN NADIA'S POCKET TO THE GUARDIAN MOTEL. YOU'RE GOING TO MAKE UP THE CLUE WHEN THEY DO SOMETHING TO DESERVE IT.

If you decide beforehand that the key is in her pocket, and your players don't think to search there, then you are going to enter into a situation I call: "is that a clue?"

Players start stabbing wildly at the answer :

- "I look at her fingernails, is that a clue?"
- "I look in her briefcase, is that a clue?"

They are no longer trying to solve a mystery, they are trying to press the skip scene button.

In real life, solving a mystery may indeed be about sifting through huge amounts of information, slowly separating the clues from the dross. But that's not what we're doing here. We're telling a story in collaboration with the players.

This is not reality. It's a story.

THE SECOND CHEAP TRICK: EVERYTHING IS A CLUE (POTENTIALLY)

"Saltwater, very bad for grass."

-The Gardener in Chinatown

If you give them a clue the first time they do something to deserve it, what are you telling them before that?

You're giving them interesting details that could later become clues.

- The dirt under the victim's fingernails smells of jasmine.

- They found saltwater in the victim's lungs.
- There's a shard of terracotta tile in the victim's big toe.

These are all interesting facts, but they don't have any inherent connection to the circumstances of the murder. Sometimes, details just give you a bit of flavor about the victim's life and don't tell you anything about their death.

Whenever your players look at anything, give them an interesting detail.

Whatever detail your players fixate on is the detail you'll later reuse to make the whole mystery look like it was prewritten.

- You notice that the Mayor has a newly planted jasmine bush in his back yard.
- The gardener tells Jake Gittes that the victim's backyard pool has saltwater in it.
- Donald is walking you to his basement to show you a bottle of liquor when you notice that his terracotta tiles are cracked.

It's simple. Make up a detail, then bring it back later when they are close to solving the case.

The trick is in timing it just right, and that just takes practice.

DEALING WITH MISTAKES - YOURS AND THE PLAYERS'

All RPGs are, at their heart, playing pretend — and the GM's job is to make sure everyone is doing the same kind of pretend.

Most problems that stall a session aren't mechanical, they're social:

- One character monopolizes the spotlight.
- No one wants to say that the scene has run out of steam.
- Despite being visibly uncomfortable, a player doesn't want to be the one to pump the brakes.

None of these have rules solutions. They have communication solutions.

The most common stall in an investigative game is the stuck interrogation —

- A player may become convinced that a suspect has more to give, so they keep asking questions, hoping the right one lands.
- There's no mechanic in *Haunted* that tells them when to stop — and there shouldn't be. That's the GM's read to make. Your call.

When you see it happening, I've found it best to just say it plainly: "I think you've got everything you're going to get from them

right now. If you think of something you wish you'd asked, bring it up later and I'll probably let you have asked it. Let's move on."

Players are almost always relieved to hear it, and had almost been waiting for permission to end the scene.

The broader principles:

- You are not the players' adversary and you are not a referee. You're the most active co-author at the table.
- When something isn't working, name it, fix it, and move on.
- The best idea wins, whoever had it.

PUTTING IT ALL TOGETHER

When you put all the tricks together, they create tension and the twists and turns we expect from a murder mystery.

ONE SHOT ADVENTURE

One of *Haunted*'s strengths is the way it uses Tarot to generate whole mysteries relatively quickly. There is still writing involved — we're not magicians — but *Haunted* presents a system that builds relationships between characters and then spawns investigation beats.

This mystery, for instance, was built by someone who'd never done it before in under four hours and with just two cups of coffee.

To run this adventure, read through the cast of characters in the courts and internalize the secrets they share with each other. As your players work the case, you may need an NPC for them to interrogate. Choose one from this list. That NPC will act in their own interests — namely protecting their secret as best they can — which will create red herrings and conflicting information for your players to parse.

THE COURTS (CAST OF CHARACTERS)

STAVES (ORDER, STATUS QUO)

To recap:

- Give the players small details that can later become relevant.
- Give them a lead which will take them to the next scene.
- Make sure that each scene creates the kind of tension that will make the story interesting.
- Ensure that the clues lead them to a satisfying climax where they catch the killer (whom you'd figured out beforehand using the campaign building section.)
- Leave them on a great cliffhanger.

The pieces of information presented in the case below represent the minimum number of plot points and clues needed for an episode of *Haunted*. The Courts represent the many potential paths your players might follow before returning to the main storyline.

Details on how this system works and how you can create mysteries rich in characters and secrets will be published in the *Haunted GM Manual*.

SETTING

Set in Crimson City, where it always rains and no one is who they seem.

THEME CARD

STRENGTH — Paving the road to Hell with good intentions.

The Parliamentarians — a growing political group with extensive ties to unions

King — Thalia Ignisci — Party leader — Thalia saw public will for a new party and started one, bringing Hector on as figurehead.

Queen — Hector Wall — The Candidate — Hector has the smile and the chin and the face/name memory system that makes people trust him. Does he have an actual plan that will fix things? Deeply unclear.

Knight — Doris Riccione — Thalia's personal assistant and niece — Doris gets the coffee and the sandwiches and the dirt on every political opponent on the field. She is quiet, efficient, and always listening.

Page — Remy Desaves — A new recruit, tasked with door-to-door canvassing. He's got the zeal of a new convert and is here to build bridges.

Ace — Arnold Wall — Hector's father, who had a political career that burned bright and fast. He's got a lot of lingering bitterness about it that poisons his relationship with his son.

PENTACLES (ACADEMICS, MAGIC)

Erishommes — an AI company on the cusp of creating AGI

King — Birdy Lopez — A tech innovator, the person with the big ideas and the inspiring stage presence. Birdy believes in a future where AI solves every problem and people live in harmony.

Queen — Jack Hallows — a "silent" partner, who reads all the bug reports and knows how far away the dream actually is.

Knight — Harvey Doser — Jack's childhood best friend, Harvey lives a life outside of the corporate bubble (and outside the norm of regular civilization) and is therefore uniquely positioned to handle any less-than-savory tasks that Jack might need doing.

Page — Patrice Wakefield — Birdy's protege, a recent MIT drop-out with a lot of potential.

Ace — Kate Lionshead — Recently retired but still consulting, Kate's code was foundational to the development of the Erishommes model. She was there in the beginning.

CUPS (CRIME, CHAOS)

Black Hats — a group of "anonymous" hackers dedicated to freedom and anarchy

King — Helene Carter — "Anon100K" — fresh college grad, wizened leader and angriest voice in any room.

Queen — Miranda Seychelle — "Seys4Keys" — highschool senior, group mod, will boot anyone who doesn't acknowledge the supremacy of her preferred coding language. Holds admin status everywhere.

Knight — Ed Carter — "Anon10K" — tech undergrad, Helene's baby brother (the family favorite), perpetually trying to earn Helene's respect.

Page — Keller Hallows — "BabaiKels" — CS under-grad, new to hacking, Jack Hallow's nephew

Ace — Eugene Depardieu — Helene's CS prof and mentor, vanished mysteriously a year ago.

SWORDS (OPEN AGGRESSION)

Wharf 16 Kings — a cult of dockworkers and fishermen, secretly devoted to the rise of a watery god.

King — Hank Merton — Owns most of the dock, fantastically wealthy, doesn't trust anyone who doesn't work on the sea.

Queen — Samson Piscan — Captain of the Clear Sky, best fisherman in the harbor. Charismatic, in a gruff, workman-like way. Lots of people owe him their jobs.

Knight — Jacob Whalen — Sailor on the Clear Sky, had a possible encounter with The One Below last year and is easily the most gungho about carrying out its Dark Requirements.

Page — Rupert Akuo — newest sailor on the Clear Sky, has heard the rumours but isn't sure that he buys them.

Ace — Gale Merton — Hank's recently deceased wife. Gale took the sloop out a while back and never returned. Her ghost sometimes wanders the docks, waterlogged and wailing.

THE SECRETS

Ace of Pentacles & Page of Pentacles - Kate Lionshead & Patrice Wakefield

Kate knows that Patrice has been recruited by the NSA and is feeding the feds corporate and technological intelligence.

Ace of Staves & Page of Cups - Arnold Wall & Keller Hallows

Arnold has been grooming his young hacker friend to destroy his son's political aspirations. He knows things about Hector that make him unfit to serve, but can't unmask him safely — enter Keller.

Ace of Swords and King of Staves - Gale Merton & Thalia Ignisci

Gale was blackmailing Thalia over Thalia's quiet history as a union-buster — wouldn't want to ruin all those blue-collar relationships in an election year, would you?

Knight of Pentacles & Queen of Staves - Harvey Doser & Hector Wall

Harvey “cleared the way” for Hector to be Candidate material — Hector's past as a clandestine operative would have kept him out of the spotlight, otherwise.

King of Cups & King of Pentacles - Helene Carter & Birdy Lopez

Helene has been obsessed with Birdy for years, and blames them for the death of her mentor, Eugene Depardieu.

THE ADVENTURE

In Haunted, the adventure is dealt before it is written — every body, every lead, every grumpy witness came off the top of a tarot deck. You don't need the deck to run it tonight, but the engine that turned a shuffle into a murder is waiting in the full game.

INCITING INCIDENT

The investigators are hired by Thalia Ignisci, whose ear in CCPD alerted her to the death: the body of Arnold Wall, long retired state

Knight of Staves & Page of Staves - Doris Riccione & Remy Desaves

Remy discovered that Doris was selling political secrets about The Parliamentarians to the Erishommes market ops team.

Ace of Cups & Queen of Swords - Eugene Depardieu & Samson Piscan

Samson sacrificed Eugene to the One Below and believes that Crimson City still exists because of that sacrifice.

Knight of Swords & Knight of Cups - Jacob Whaler & Ed Carter

Jacob and Ed look distressingly alike, so much so that they get mistaken for each other all the time. This means that they end up taking heat for each others crimes without the security of being able to rely on a double for an alibi.

King of Swords and Queen of Cups - Hank Merton & Miranda Seychelle

Miranda is Hank's secret daughter, an affair baby, his only child, which might make her a perfect sacrifice to The One Below.

Queen of Pentacles & Page of Swords - Jack Hallows & Rupert Akuo

Rupert discovered that Jack has been hiding the toxic effects of Erishommes' water usage — a secret that could destroy Erishommes.

politician and father to the leading candidate of The Parliamentarians, was found washed up on the beach near the Crimson City harbor, home to the bustling docks and water treatment facility.

Thalia guards the body from lookielooks while she waits for the authorities (who are somehow “too busy” to set up a crime scene), and talking to her reveals that she'd held suspicions that Arnold was up to something shady, though she's not sure what.

Arnold's body shows the effects of crabs and other tide-pool creatures, but no signs of struggle or pre-mortem injury — seems like a relatively straightforward drowning, strange in shallow water.

Found close to or on his person is a waterlogged notebook containing what seem to be “angel numbers”.

Jacob Whalen, a witness on the docks (or CCTV footage of the docks, whatever), reports that two nights ago he saw Wall and a second, obscured person, walking down the dock, trailed by a dog.

The lead that brings investigators to the next scene is information that Hector Wall, the victim's son, is mid-campaign event *right now* on the boardwalk.

MIDPOINT ESCALATION

The investigators hit the boardwalk and find Hector giving a speech, highlighting the Greater Good to be done and casting down anyone who won't lend their strength to the cause of a better Crimson City.

Once they are able to speak to him alone, they find that he knows about his father's death (“What, you think Thalia called you before me?”) and that he's not especially broken up by it. Apparently their relationship was strained, at best.

But he has an alibi for two nights ago - he and Thalia and the whole Parliamentarian crew were at an event for the Dockworkers Union, and he'd been shadowed by a liaison all evening - Rupert Akuo, right over there.

When the investigators speak to Rupert, he confirms Hector's story - but he also mentions a couple other weird disappearances: Gale Merton, Eugene Depardieu - and Rupert tells the investigators in hushed tones, looking anxiously over his shoulder, about the eerie vibe he's been picking up from his coworkers.

Sometimes, after a few too many beers, they'll talk about the One Below, and its dark requirements, and the things that sailors

will do to satisfy it. And stories are stories, Rupert knows that, but sometimes, when they're out on the boat, he sees lights in the distance, lights under the cliff face, where there're just rocks and waves.

He's telling the investigators about the weird sounds over the water when Jacob Whalen interrupts and pulls Rupert away - it's low tide, and Rupert's fancy political connections won't scrape limpets off the Clear Sky's hull.

LOWPOINT

The investigators go looking under the cliff-face, climbing over boulders and enduring sea spray, and at first, it looks like it's just tidepools and rocks, until they turn a corner and find a cave.

A hole in the cliff-face that has clearly been enlarged to be a doorway, most of the time under water, dark and damp, with a path that carves deep into the rock. From within, they hear a shuddering groan, deep and inhuman.

With the tide coming in, the investigators dare to venture into the cave.

It is dark and echoey, and their feet slip off seaweed encrusted rocks, and sometimes the water floods in and rushes over their ankles. But eventually, they see a light - an electric light, and some stairs that go up.

The door at the top of the stairs opens onto a server/generator farm. At least twenty-four humming machines arrayed in racks, lights blinking, fans roaring.

Beyond them is another door, which opens onto what can only be described as a Hacker Lair - the walls are bright with monitors and flashing neon LEDs, the desks are festooned with snack garbage and fidget toys. A teenager, Miranda Seychelle, spins around to confront the investigators.

She won't explain the purpose of the hacker collective, demanding instead to see the investigators' credentials before denying having anything at all to do with the docks or anyone who goes missing from them.

But the sharp-eyed investigators will spy a

notebook on a desk on which is written the same “angel numbers” found near Arnold Wall’s body. Miranda doesn’t know what those are and doesn’t really care - she doesn’t deal with whatever it is that the intern does all day.

At that moment, the second door to the lair opens, revealing Keller Hallows. “The pigs are concerned with your notebook, kid,” crows the high school senior, and Keller bolts back up the stairs, followed at speed by his dog.

CLIMAX

Therefore, a chase. Keller rushes up the way he just came down, a set of steep stairs that reach a ranger’s hut at the top of the cliff, bursting through doors that barely hang together, and over windswept grasses made slick with rain.

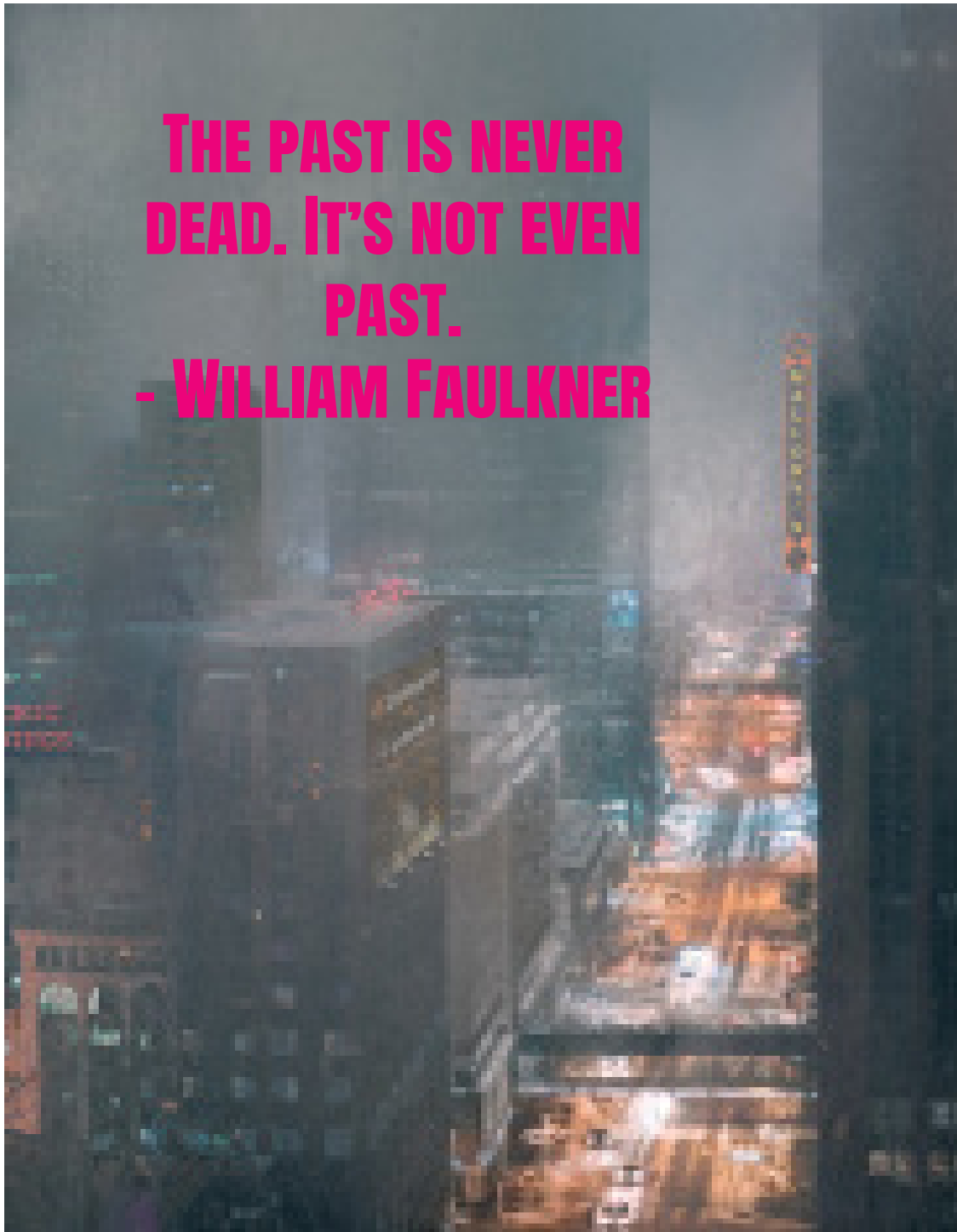
When the investigators catch him, she reveals that Arnold had discovered the hackers’ nest one day while beach combing and

had coerced him into sabotaging his son’s political aspirations, saying that Hector’s candidacy was a sham, and that his past should disqualify him from office.

He wanted Keller to find evidence of Hector’s misdeeds and expose him, but the more he looked, the less he found, and the more he came to genuinely believe in Hector.

Finally, Arnold tried to force his hand by threatening to expose the Black Hats, and Keller felt that he had no choice. He drugged Arnold’s coffee and pushed him into the water, letting him drown unseen under the docks.

The investigators may ask him to confirm that he killed Arnold because he was threatening the collective - he murmurs half-hearted agreement, but adds - “The worst thing was that I finally found it, the crime that Arnold knew was Hector’s.” What was it? “The world is better off not knowing.” And with that, he launches himself off the cliff.



**THE PAST IS NEVER
DEAD. IT'S NOT EVEN
PAST.
- WILLIAM FAULKNER**

HAUNTED – QUICK REFERENCE

Keep this in the middle of the table.

THE DRAW

When something uncertain and interesting happens, draw one card.

You only draw when a skill is in play and the stakes are real. If there's no chance of success, or no cost to failing, don't draw – just say what happens.

Card	Result
Major Arcana	Full success. You got what you wanted, clean.
Court card (Page, Knight, Queen, King, Ace)	Complicated success — if you have a relevant skill. Without one, treat it as a numbered card.
Numbered card (2–10)	Pyrrhic success, or a failure if you'd rather.

INJURIES

Boxes fill in order.

	One check per session is at Disadvantage
	Disadvantage on all checks
	Debilitated — you fail all checks

The GM decides which checks an injury or trauma applies to. There is no natural healing in *Haunted*.

THE COST

Complicated success: you got what you were going for, and one bad thing also happens. The GM decides what.

Pyrrhic success: you got it, and now you're looking at two bad things, or one significant one. If it's bad enough, you can ask the GM to let you fail instead. Sometimes a contained failure beats a catastrophic win.

After every draw, the table reads the card. The image is an invitation - the best interpretation usually comes from everyone throwing out ideas and seeing what clicks. The GM has the final call.

ADVANTAGE AND DISADVANTAGE

Situation in your favor — Advantage. Draw two, use the better result.
Situation against you — Disadvantage. Draw two, use the worse result.

TRAUMA

Boxes fill in order.

	Describe your character trying to keep their cool
	One check per session is at Disadvantage
	Traumatized — you cannot use your abilities

SKILLS

Busting Heads	Fighting, chasing, powering through. Action movie stuff.
Delude	Lying, fast talking, persuasion, disguise, bureaucracy. Spy stuff.
Eyeball	Noticing small details, being alert, searching. Cop stuff.
Get Under Their Skin	Seduction, intimidation, unsettling someone. Provocateur stuff.
Give 'Em the Slip	Escaping, sneaking, dodging, pickpocketing. Hoodlum stuff.
Hit the Books	Research, library use, the internet, cyberstalking. Nerd stuff.

If two skills could apply, talk it out with your GM.

THREE THINGS THAT ARE ALWAYS TRUE

You cannot fail to find a clue. Every lead you follow will produce something. It may cost you, but you will always come away with more than you had.

You cannot fail when checking to gain evidence.

The mystery is ALWAYS solvable. Trust the process.

SO THAT'S HAUNTED.

If tonight worked — if somebody drew the Tower at the worst possible moment, if the table argued about what a card meant and landed somewhere better than any of you would have gotten alone — there's a lot more where that came from.

WHAT YOU DIDN'T GET TONIGHT

Everything here is one session's worth of a game built for campaigns. The full release includes:

The Player's Manual — all six playbooks in full, character creation, the world of *Haunted*, and a player's guide to roleplaying in it.

The GM Manual — running the mystery, building a campaign, prepping a session, and the story rhythm that holds a case together across months of play.

Six trifold playbooks — the Bull, the Medium, the Reader, the Shamus, the Shrink, and the Uppercrust.

Core Wound cards and Spell cards.

Downtime and the Redemption Arc — the second story running underneath the casework. Every investigator is haunted by someone. Over four downtime scenes, they get one chance to make peace with it.

Tonight you played the case. The campaign is about the wound.

All art by paid human artists. Written by a person. Every word of it.

TELL US HOW IT WENT

We're still listening. If you ran this, we want to know what worked, what confused you, and what your table did that we didn't see coming.

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Haunted was selected for Gamefound's RPG Party 2026. Follow the campaign now and you'll know the moment it goes live.

THE FULL GAME LAUNCHES ON GAMEFOUND - OCTOBER 1, 2026

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burzerkerr-studios/haunted](https://gamefound.com/en/projects/burzerkerr-studios/haunted)



Written by Jeremy Kerr
Lead Artist Belgin Kaya, with Melody
Durham and Oliver Guiney
Burzerkerr Studios LLC
Haunted requires a standard 78-card tarot
deck. Play it with people you trust.